



THE DIGITAL MALAWI ACCELERATION PROJECT

GRANT NUMBER:
PROJECT NUMBER:

IDA-E338-MW
P505095

Provision of a turnkey solution for the rehabilitation, upgrading, and commissioning of the Central Printing Facility including design, supply, installation and handover for full operational readiness

We received request for clarifications regarding the above captioned procurement activity and in the spirit of fairness and transparency, the clarifications together with the questions are shared in the Table below.

Table 1: Responses to requests to Clarifications

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
Section III, Paragraph 1.4.1 – General Experience	The JV qualification matrix appears to indicate that each JV member must independently demonstrate at least five years of experience under Information System contracts. Could you please confirm whether this interpretation is correct?	Bidders are advised that composition of joint venture members depends on the parties involved and the Lead is determined by the members to the JV. The requirement as provided under Paragraph 1.4.1 is indeed correct.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	Given the turnkey nature of the project, we understand that a JV could comprise complementary partners, with one member responsible primarily for facility rehabilitation/construction and another for IT, card production and information systems. We would therefore appreciate confirmation on whether the five-year Information System experience requirement must indeed be met by each JV member, rather than being satisfied collectively according to the respective roles of the JV members	
Section VII, Clause 1.1.1	We respectfully request permission to conduct an additional site visit to inspect the facility. Such a visit would enable our technical team and specialist partners to: • Verify existing site conditions and dimensions. • Assess construction and renovation requirements. • Evaluate facility infrastructure, including electrical, HVAC, fire protection, and ICT systems. • Assess physical security requirements and existing security controls. • Identify access constraints, operational considerations, and installation requirements for the proposed equipment and systems. • Improve the accuracy of the proposed rehabilitation design, methodology, implementation plan, schedule, and pricing May the Purchaser please provide a copy of the following:	Bidders may arrange for another site visit on their own through the following contacts: Contact Person: Mr. Sacha Miteche Telephone Number: +265 (0) 997 657 203 E-Mail Address: sacha.miteche@nrb.gov.mw The National Digitization Policy and the National Registration Act are hereby attached.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	Malawi's National Digitalization Policy The National Registration Act of 2015	
Section 1.4.1.5	Clause 1.4.1.5, System Security Features, requires digital signature enforcement for card personalization, hardware security modules for cryptographic operations, and a secure key management lifecycle covering generation, storage, rotation and revocation. Clause 1.6.11.4 requires PKI compliance with X.509 standards and alignment with eIDAS digital signature standards. Based on this clause, may the purchaser please confirm whether they will be providing a certification authority	The Public Key Infrastructure (PKI) solution shall be provisioned and made available by the Purchaser.
Section VII: 1.3/ 1.4 / 1.6; Clarification response to the chip question 1.3.1.2.2.1; 1.4.1.5; 3.4; Purchaser response, "The NRB currently prints digitally signed biometric QR code"	In responding to the question on chip scope, the Purchaser stated that "The NRB currently prints digitally signed biometric QR code which includes the biodata, face and fingerprint biometric information". With the chip now excluded from scope, this statement is the sole description of the cryptographic function the Information System is required to perform, and the personalization software, the hardware security module provision and the key management lifecycle are all configured against it. We have examined a current Malawi National ID card and read the QR code printed on it. The data recovered Comprises the machine-readable zone only. We did not recover a facial image or any fingerprint data. We note that a facial image together with two fingerprint templates would ordinarily require several tens of kilobytes, which exceeds what a QR code of a size and module density readable by a standard verification device can carry on a card of ID-1	The data embedded within the QR code will include the holder's biodata, fingerprint, and facial image data. The Purchaser is currently optimizing the QR code to reduce its physical footprint and will communicate the finalized dimensions to the Supplier. Under this contract, the Supplier will collaborate directly with the Purchaser to redesign the Malawi National ID card, ensuring the layout seamlessly integrates the digitally signed QR code. To read the secure QR code contents, devices must have standard scanning capabilities and run specialized software equipped with the appropriate security decryption keys. The Purchaser will provide the successful Supplier with full technical specifications, including digital signing protocols, data formats, and structural schemas. .

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	format, whereas a machine-readable zone occupies fewer than one hundred characters. These two positions cannot both be correct, and they lead to materially different solutions. We should therefore be grateful for the Purchaser's clarification of the following: (a) What data elements is the QR code required to carry on the cards to be produced under this contract? Please confirm specifically whether a facial image and fingerprint data are to be included, and if so in what format and at what template size, for example ISO/IEC 19794. (b) If biometric data is to be carried, please confirm the QR code version, error correction level and printed dimensions the Purchaser requires, and confirm the verification devices with which the code must be readable. (c) Is the QR code to be digitally signed? If so, over which data elements is the signature computed, and what signature format and data structure is required? (d) Is the new card required to be interoperable with QR verification applications or readers already deployed by the National Registration Bureau? If so, please provide the specification of the existing data structure, or confirm that the Supplier may define it.	
Section VII: 1.4/ 1.6 1.4.1.5; 1.6.2.1; 1.6.4; 1.6.11.4	Clause 1.4.1.5 requires digital signature enforcement for card personalization, hardware security modules for cryptographic operations, and a secure key management lifecycle covering generation, storage, rotation and revocation.	The Department of e-Government is responsible for providing the Malawi Government's Public Key Infrastructure (PKI). Bidders must not procure a new PKI; instead, they must plan to utilize the e-

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	Digital signatures of this kind are produced using signing certificates, which must be issued by a certification authority. The request for proposals does not state whether that certification authority is to be provided by the Supplier or is retained by the National Registration Bureau. The distinction is material to price and to scope. If the Purchaser operates a certification authority, the Supplier provides document signing components and integrates to it, and the work is interface definition, certificate enrolment and participation in a key ceremony. If the Supplier is to provide the certification authority, the solution additionally requires a root certification authority, its directory, offline key ceremony arrangements and the governance around them, which is a substantially larger scope. We should be grateful for the Purchaser's clarification of the following: (a) Does the National Registration Bureau operate a certification authority today, and is it to be used to issue the signing certificates used by the Information System? (b) If so, is that certification authority to be retained, upgraded or replaced under this contract, and is the Supplier required to assess its suitability? (c) If the Supplier is to provide the certification authority, please confirm whether it is to be a root authority operated by the Purchaser after handover, the certificate policy and certification practice statement requirements that apply, and whether an offline root with an associated key ceremony is required.	Government PKI that will be provisioned for the National Registration Bureau (NRB)

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	(d) Which party holds the signing keys and the associated hardware security modules after Operational Acceptance, and which party is responsible for certificate renewal and revocation thereafter?	
Section VII: 1.3/ 1.4; Implementation Schedule 1.3.1.2.2.1.4; 1.4 (DR synchronization); Site Table, Section VII	Clause 1.3.1.2.2.1.4 requires a primary production environment, a secondary disaster recovery environment, backup replication infrastructure and offsite backup storage, and clause 1.4 refers to disaster recovery synchronization between primary and secondary sites. The Site Table in Section VII, however, identifies a single delivery site, being the National Registration Bureau headquarters at Capital Hill, Lilongwe, and the Implementation Schedule lists that site alone against every milestone. A secondary environment cannot be designed, delivered or priced without knowing where it is and who provides it. We should be grateful for the Purchaser's clarification of the following: (a) Is a physically separate secondary site required, and if so, is the facility to be provided by the Purchaser or by the Supplier? (b) If the facility is provided by the Purchaser, please identify the location, and confirm whether it is an existing data centre, its available power, cooling, floor loading and rack space, and its physical security arrangements. (c) Is the renovation scope at clause 3.5 to be read as applying to the primary site only, or does it extend to preparing a secondary site? (d) Which party provides the network connectivity between the two sites, and what bandwidth and latency is available? The	The Purchaser operates an NRIS Disaster Recovery Site within a secure Data Center located in Blantyre. In this tender, facility rehabilitations are restricted exclusively to the primary site's designated card printing facility. Wide Area Network (WAN) connectivity is pre-established via the Malawi Government Wide Area Network, and the NRB will handle all WAN provisioning. Bidders must ensure that the secondary environment is fully functional and operational at the Operational Acceptance stage.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	requirement for synchronization within five minutes cannot be assessed without this. (e) Is the secondary environment required to be in operation at Operational Acceptance, or may it be delivered as a subsequent phase?	
Section VII: 1.3/ 1.5 / 2.1; Site Table 1.3.1.3; 1.5.2.2.3; 2.1.3; Section VII Site Table	The requirements assume data communications between the Central Printing Facility, the disaster recovery environment and the National Registration and Identity System. Clause 1.3.1.3 requires a segregated network architecture; clause 1.5.2.2.3 requires data synchronization between the primary and disaster recovery sites; and clause 2.1.3 requires integration services exchanging data between NRIS and the personalization system. Each depends on wide area circuits, and remote support of the delivered system depends on an internet service at the site. The RFP does not state which party provides these services. It is conventional for the Purchaser to provide connectivity, and that is the more natural reading for a Purchaser-provided disaster recovery site. It is less clear at the Central Printing Facility, where the Supplier is responsible for the rehabilitation, upgrading and commissioning of the facility. The position on internet access is unstated for both sites. It is less clear at the Central Printing Facility, where the Supplier is responsible for the rehabilitation, upgrading and commissioning of the facility. We should be grateful for the Purchaser's clarification of the following: (a) Is the Purchaser providing the wide area circuits between the Central Printing	Internet and WAN connectivity are provided via the Malawi Government Wide Area Network (GWAN). The Supplier is required to define all technical network requirements, which the Purchaser will then provision.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	Facility, the disaster recovery site and NRIS, or are these to be provided by the Supplier? (b) Is the Purchaser providing internet access at the Central Printing Facility and at the disaster recovery site, over which the Supplier's remote support connectivity would run? Where it is not provided at either site, is the Supplier permitted to arrange it? (c) Where any of these are to be provided by the Supplier, may the Purchaser provide any requirements as to carrier selection or service arrangements, so that they can be priced?	
Section 3.4.6.1 Polycarbonate Cards	Can the Procurement Authority please confirm if the card construction must be only 6 layers, or is a minimum of 6+ layers acceptable?	Card configurations must feature a minimum of six (6) layers. Proposals exceeding this minimum requirement (6+ layers) are welcome, provided they deliver advanced security options for the Purchaser
Section 3.4.2 Polycarbonate Cards	Concern Given that thermochromic ink commonly used in security applications has an activation temperature of approximately 27°C, temperatures in a hot climate that occasionally exceed the activation threshold can affect the feature's performance and reliability during verifications/inspections. Suggestion Would the Procurement Authority consider removing the requirement for thermochromic ink, or allow proposed alternative security features that provide consistent verification performance across a broader range of operating and environmental conditions?	The Supplier must strictly comply with industry-standard temperature requirements for secure card production. Furthermore, the inclusion of thermochromic ink is a mandatory technical specification that cannot be omitted or modified

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
Section 3.4.2 & 3.4.3 Polycarbonate Cards	Concern While OVMI is an acceptable security feature for national identity cards, it is not commonly implemented on cards. OVMI requires a relatively large, printed area to be effective during visual inspection, which would limit the remaining available space for mandatory personalized data or other security features. OVI, however, is more commonly implemented on cards and can provide comparable visual authentication benefits while requiring significantly less space. Furthermore, the implementation of OVMI for cards requires specialized printing press equipment configurations, which can result in higher production costs compared to OVI. Suggestion Would the Procurement Authority consider revising the OVMI requirement to 'OVI' on both sides of the card, as this approach would be more commonly supported among card vendors, optimize available card space, and reduce manufacturing complexity and cost.	The requirement for OVMI is a mandatory technical specification. No modifications will be made to this specification based on individual bidder proposals.
Section 3.4.6.1 Polycarbonate Cards	To respect the sensitivity of Government interests from other countries regarding information contained lab test reports, would the Procurement Authority accept redacted lab reports? Also, can the Procurement Authority confirm the quantity of lab test reports required?	To facilitate a comprehensive technical evaluation, the Supplier is required to submit at-least two laboratory test reports. The Purchaser will accept redacted reports, provided they contain sufficient information for technical comparison
Section 1.3.1.1.2.1.3 Architectural requirements	Can the Procurement Authority clearly describe what the 'Graphical layout designer/editor for card template design' is (e.g. digital preview of the card before personalization; a human designer; other)?	A graphical layout designer is required to redesign the Malawi National ID template for the polycarbonate cards. The Supplier shall work closely with the

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		Purchaser to design the new blank ID cards for the Malawi National ID.
Section 3.4.5.1 Polycarbonate Cards	Can the Procurement Authority clarify when (tentative date) production testing' would occur in the project?	The project implementation schedule falls under the responsibility of the Supplier. The Purchaser will not impose a fixed date for production testing; instead, the Supplier must define this milestone within their proposed deployment plan.
Section 3.4.2 & 3.4.3 Polycarbonate Cards	Can the Procurement Authority confirm if the "photonic crystal" feature (previously described by the Procurement Authority as a security layer) is required on both sides of the card?	The primary requirement is for the photonic crystal to be deployed on the front side of the card. However, the Purchaser will consider dual-sided designs should the Supplier choose to propose them for enhanced security.
Section 1.3 - 1.3.1.1.2.1.1	The clause requires web-based administration portals for presentation layer. What exactly do the Purchaser want to administrate using a web-based portal? Is this related to user management?	The system management operations for both the personalization and mailing solutions must feature a secure, web-based administration interface.
3.5 Renovation of Premises	We kindly request that the Purchaser make available the following information: 1. Existing floor plans and architectural drawings of the facility. 2. Structural and civil engineering drawings and reports, where available. 3. Mechanical and electrical services drawings, including power distribution, HVAC, and fire protection systems. 4. ICT and structured cabling layouts, if available. 5. Any available facility condition assessments, as-built drawings, or site survey reports. 6. Information regarding existing physical security infrastructure, including access control systems, CCTV coverage, secure storage areas, and other relevant security measures	The ground floor plan for the designated rehabilitation and card production area is provided. The Supplier shall design the new facility layout without accounting for any existing electrical, HVAC, ICT, or security infrastructure. The Purchaser will supply a separate, dedicated electrical power connection based entirely on the Supplier's final approved design specifications.
Polycarbonate Card – Laboratory Testing (Page 170)	The RFP requires testing by "one of the leading Polycarbonate Card Labs of the world." Kindly clarify what reference or benchmark will be used	Card testing must be conducted by an independent international laboratory that holds trusted government mandates for national ID security. The facility must

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	by the Purchaser to determine whether a laboratory qualifies as a “leading Polycarbonate Card Lab of the world	possess industrial-grade hardware and hold active accreditations required to stress-test cards against top global benchmarks
Polycarbonate Card – Testing Laboratory Accreditation (Page 170)	Kindly confirm whether ISO/IEC 17025 accreditation with an appropriate accredited scope for the specified card testing standards will be considered an acceptable qualification for the testing laboratory.	The listed ISO/IEC accreditations are the minimum requirements. Bidders may submit additional or equivalent accreditations to demonstrate enhanced capabilities.
Polycarbonate Card – Sample Card Images / Physical Samples (Page 169)	Kindly clarify the quantity, format, and submission method of the physical polycarbonate card samples required to be submitted along with the bid, including the required number of blank or pre personalized samples.	Bidders are advised to submit at least two physical samples together with their bid. The samples should be blank or pre personalized, that is, either blank or from previous assignments.
Polycarbonate Card – Lamination Requirement	Kindly clarify whether Lamination process is required and, if so, please provide the applicable technical specifications. the RFP does not explicitly indicate whether a lamination machine or lamination module is required to be supplied and installed as part of the proposed system.	The technical specifications do not mandate a specific lamination process or equipment. However, bidders are free to propose additional equipment, such as a laminator, if deemed necessary to meet the overall card durability standards outlined in this bid document.
In order to finalize our comprehensive and competitive proposal, we are currently awaiting the final pricing details from our OEMs. The additional time will enable us to complete the commercial evaluation and finalize our bid pricing in line with the technical requirements of the tender. In view of the above, we kindly request that the bid submission deadline be extended by 7 (Seven) days		Bidders are advised that no further extensions will be provided. The closing date for bid submission therefore remains 13 October 2026 as revised under Addendum No. 3

It is our hope that the responses provided will assist in finalizing your proposal.

Kind Regards